

We can't ever catch up our housing, health or infrastructure while immigration increases our population.

This is a summary of the main points in a forthcoming book. But with the election looming, I hope that this issue can be recognised as so important that it should be put to the competing parties. I hope, too, that some commentator, more influential than I, might be persuaded to run with it.

Simply put, we are short on almost every component of our civilised life, doctors, hospitals, houses, electricity, roads, prisons, medical schools, clean water supplies and sewers. But we are only so short because the rate at which we catch up is exceeded by the rate our population increases. And while we have our policy of fiscal constraint, and have limited 'build' capacity, we have no hope, at present, of keeping up with any population increases, especially if the rate of those increases continue to vary unpredictably from year to year.

But, you may ask, is not our fertility now so low that the population would fall from that cause alone? And do we not lose greater numbers to overseas than we regain from their return? Both are true, and we depend on immigration, both temporary and permanent to make up the shortfall.

Immigration is beneficial in that regard. However, the numbers and makeup are driven by factors other than our capacity to provide for them, and we make it worse when we invite so many immigrants that our population increases, and increases so much that our shortages in general become ever worse. Some merely remain critical despite our skilled immigrants. We do need immigration, especially of medical staff, but, in general, not so as to increase our population.

There are two publications that cover the ground:

Ann Beaglehole's history of immigration regulation in <https://teara.govt.nz/en/immigration-regulation/print> shows us that we have long used immigration policy to gain skills and capital, reunite families, accept some refugees, and impose bigotry.

Productivity Commission: Immigration – Fit for the future. Preliminary findings and recommendations in <https://www.treasury.govt.nz/sites/default/files/2024-05/pc-inq-is-immigration-summary.pdf> which includes the recommendation to **"Change the law to require the Government to give explicit consideration to how well New Zealand can successfully accommodate and settle new arrivals.** Current law gives the Crown complete discretion in determining the “national interest” in immigration. The ability to absorb new people is an overriding factor and should be included in Government decisions about the volume and make-up of migrant intakes."

That recommendation is required, and should be made binding, because our current, arbitrary immigration decisions, when they result in population increase, however well-meaning and useful in other respects they may, or may not, be, are quite certainly and provably destructive of our general quality of life and of the well being of one of the largest groups in our society — the less well-off.

But for all of us: our sewers are old, our hospitals overcrowded, many streets in gridlock, electricity capacity sometimes so low that it is rationed by price increases that are driving industry away, many of our youth are unemployed, our prisons are overcrowded, ambulance services over-taxed — all have various causes, but population growth is one of the more significant.

While such problems continue to vex us we need an immigration policy that concentrates on key skills, but does not increase our population.

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